

Daniel Mercer

Integrative counselling for adults · Sheffield and online

PREPARED BY

Alexander Watson Studio

STAGE

Before website design

STATUS

For your review

DATE

September 2026

This is where the website gets decided.

A Practice Clarity Blueprint settles the strategy for your practice before any design begins: how the practice is described, who the site should speak to first, how it should sound, and how it should look. Once it is agreed, the build works from these pages instead of reopening them.

Read it as a description of your practice that you are entitled to correct. Where a fact is wrong, correct it. Where the wording is right but not yours, say so too.

UNDERSTANDING THE PRACTICE

- 01 Practice at a glance
- 02 Professional identity
- 03 Philosophy of practice
- 04 The people you want to reach
- 05 Messaging and voice
- 06 Intended client experience

CREATIVE RECOMMENDATION

- 07 Brand direction
- 08 Logo and identity
- 09 Colour
- 10 Typography
- 11 Photography and imagery
- 12 Website translation

SUMMARY AND APPROVAL

- 13 Practice Clarity Snapshot
- 14 Approval and next step

TO CONFIRM BEFORE PUBLICATION

Qualification and awarding body · Professional register and membership number · Insurance · Supervision arrangement · Room address and access

Deliberately blank, along with anything you want stated about your own therapy. Your professional standing will take one sentence on the site, and nothing of that kind appears until you supply the particulars.

HOW TO READ IT

- **Established.** Facts you have given us. Nothing factual has been assumed; anything not yet established is listed below rather than filled in.
- **Interpretation.** Our reading of what you told us. Much of this document is interpretation, and correcting it is the main purpose of your review.
- **Recommendation.** What we are proposing for the identity and the website. Approve, adjust or refuse it.

Each page is marked at the top right. The first six sections set out our understanding of the practice; the next six turn it into creative recommendations.

Built for the point before it becomes serious.

THE PRACTITIONER

An integrative counsellor working in Sheffield and online. Eight years in practice; eleven before that as an engineer.

THE PEOPLE

Adults who are still working, parenting and earning, and who would not describe themselves as unwell. Most of them are men.

THE CENTRAL CONCERN

The gap between managing and being alright. A way of coping that worked for years has stopped paying, and its failure is confusing rather than obvious.

THE FEELING TO CREATE

Ordinariness. Not calm, not sanctuary. A normal service used by normal people, which does not ask anyone to become a different sort of person to use it.

“Most of the people I see are men, and most of them had never pictured themselves doing this.”

DANIEL MERCER, AT DISCOVERY

THE PRACTICAL FACTS

Fee	£60
Session length	50 minutes
Frequency	Weekly, at the same time
Delivery	Sheffield and online
First conversation	Free, fifteen minutes

Explains the work, and says what he notices.

Plain by discipline, not by simplification

You use the word *integrative* and then define it in a single clause. You do not avoid technical language; you refuse to leave it unexplained.

Observant, and unwilling to sit on it

Staying quiet when you think something matters appears in the list of things you *won't* do. Stated as a refusal, it is a harder promise than a virtue.

Undramatic

No couch. No stage where anyone has to cry. The deflation is repeated often enough to be a position rather than a mannerism.

Explicit about money and limits

The fee, the cancellation terms and the work you don't take are stated in full. Naming what you will not do is what makes the rest of the page believable.

Not an authority on someone else's life

Two of your refusals guard the same boundary: telling a client what to do with their life, and pretending to know them better than they know themselves.

A first career, used as evidence

Eleven years as an engineer is not offered as a credential. It is offered as the same pattern — *"I was good at it and quietly miserable. I'd have said I was fine. I said it a lot."*

A counsellor who explains his work in ordinary language, says what he notices, and treats the mechanics of therapy — the room, the fee, the process, the limits — as information you are entitled to before you arrive.

IDENTITY STATEMENT

Nobody has to arrive able to explain it.

Our reading of the position you described. It decides what the website is organised around, so it is worth disagreeing with if we have it wrong.

A way of coping that worked for years can make its own failure confusing rather than obvious. Nothing has collapsed; on paper, and to most people who know them, the person is fine — and that is often what removes the obvious justification for asking for help.

In your account of the work, the material is not limited to what a client can already explain. Some of it is what an attentive person can see and is willing to say out loud. Articulacy may come out of that; you do not treat it as a condition of entering it.

The change you describe is gradual and behavioural rather than dramatic: it shows up at home, over months, in how things get handled.

Managing isn't the same as being alright.

DEFINING BELIEF, IN YOUR OWN WORDS

WHAT FOLLOWS FROM IT

- Not knowing what is wrong is a normal starting point, not a failure of preparation — *“I’ll ask what brought you. If you don’t know, we start there.”*
- The first session cannot be failed. Turning up without an explanation is not a wasted fifty minutes.
- What you notice, said out loud, is most of what a client is paying for. That is your claim, and it is one about competence rather than warmth.
- No outcome is promised anywhere, consistently enough to read as a position rather than a style.

Still coping, and privately confused by it.

This sets who the website should speak to most directly — a question of emphasis in the writing, not a limit on who you will see. The outward facts came from you; what is happening underneath is our reading of them.

VISIBLE FROM OUTSIDE

Still working, still parenting, still earning. Nothing has collapsed. On paper, and to most people who know them, fine.

HAPPENING INSIDE

Anger arriving faster than it used to. Anxiety managed so long it now feels like personality. Grief with no vocabulary attached. Sometimes one thing never said aloud.

WHAT MAKES IT HARD TO APPROACH

It doesn't feel serious enough to qualify. There are no words ready. There is an expectation of being analysed, patronised, or asked to perform an emotion.

WHAT THEY HOPE FOR

To understand what is happening and to react differently. To say the thing once, out loud, to someone who won't flinch. Not to become their best self — you don't offer that, and they would not believe it.

TWO THINGS THEY ARE WARY OF

Being asked to perform. The suspicion is that therapy has a house style of speech that has to be adopted in order to take part, and that arriving without it wastes the hour.

Being handled. Warmth offered before anything factual has been established can read as technique, and reassurance can sound like selling.

On the skew. Most of the people you see are men. Our reading is that men are over-represented among those carrying this particular cost, rather than that the practice is for men — the barrier the site removes is the positioning, not the gender. Two things worth naming rather than assuming: many are prompted by someone else, and many arrive with no clear problem at all.

One message, and no vocabulary to learn.

You don't have to be good at talking to start.

PRIMARY MESSAGE

THE THRESHOLD IS LOWER THAN IT LOOKS

Things don't have to be falling apart first. Some people arrive with a very clear problem; others know only that things aren't working particularly well. Both are stated as enough.

HOW IT SHOULD SOUND

Short declaratives. Ordinary nouns. Specific quantities. A full stop where a lesser site would use a comma. Dry rather than funny, and never funny at the client's expense.

The second person is used, but for practical instruction and for naming a fear precisely before answering it — never to tell the reader what they are feeling.

THERE IS NO MYSTERY IN THE METHOD

No couch. Two chairs and fifty minutes. Four numbered steps from an email to a weekly session, and a therapist who says what he is doing and why.

EMBRACE

- Named fears, answered with facts
- Numbers stated openly
- Refusals, written out in full
- Situations in the reader's own phrasing
- Deflation by specificity

THE LIMITS ARE STATED TOO

What you notice, said out loud. What you will not do, listed. And that if you are not the right person, you will say so — which is what makes the rest credible.

AVOID

- Safe space, journey, holding space
- Authentic self, transformational, potential
- Any promise of an outcome
- Diagnostic categories and condition lists
- Adjective stacks and exclamation marks

From a car park at six to a three-line email.

FEEL

Recognised without being exposed. Spoken to as an adult. Not required to perform, and not expected to already understand how therapy works. The target is not calm. It is that the service reads as ordinary.

UNDERSTAND

Within seconds: what it costs, how long a session is, where it happens, what the first one is like, and that not knowing what to say is a normal way to begin.

TRUST

Built from transparency rather than assertion: the fee, the terms, the limits and the refusals are all published, including the ones it would be easier to leave out.

DO

Send a short email — three lines, or none — or ask for the free fifteen minutes, in which anything may be asked, including whether you are the right person.

THE ARC

Arrival

One claim, one photograph of the room, and the fee. Scepticism is answered before feeling is asked for.

Recognition

Eight situations in the reader’s own phrasing, with no condition named. The reader recognises something before learning anything about you.

Understanding

How the work goes, in four numbered steps — and then, in the same breath, the things you won’t do.

Contact

A form asking for a name and an email address, whose message field says three lines is plenty, or leave it blank.

STATED IN YOUR OWN VOICE, AS CONTENT RATHER THAN SMALL PRINT

First floor, reached by stairs · Cancellation terms in full · Couples work not offered · The four steps, before anyone has to ask

It should look like somewhere business is done.

The identity should read as a well-made public document: structural, high-contrast, unornamented. Closer to a good technical report than to a clinic, and further still from anything that reads as wellness.

The reason is not taste. Fine serifs, cream, botanical motifs and soft pastels are the visual language of a category many of these visitors may not recognise themselves in. Meeting them there asks for an act of translation before a sentence has been read.

So the design is asked to carry no atmosphere at all. Everything the visitor is meant to feel arrives as information: what it costs, what happens, what you won't do.

WHAT IT CARRIES

- One argument, at the largest size on the page
- Facts set as facts, in a second typeface
- Space as evidence of composure, not ceremony
- Exactly one colour, meaning “this is the way in”
- Contrast high enough that nothing is hunted for

WHAT IT AVOIDS

- Serifs, cream grounds, botanicals, pastels
- Cards, shadows, rounded corners, icon sets
- Gradients, textures, a second accent
- Stock photography of calm
- Anything that raises the price of entry

PRACTICE — AUDIENCE — MESSAGE — EXPERIENCE — IDENTITY — VISUAL SYSTEM — WEBSITE

Every decision in sections 07 to 12 is traceable back to a conclusion in sections 01 to 06. Anything that is not traceable is decoration.

Nothing on the walls worth commenting on.

DESIGN PRINCIPLE, IN YOUR OWN WORDS

A name and a rule.

There is no symbol, and we are not proposing one. A practice whose first promise is that nothing here is mysterious should not carry a mark that has to be explained, and a monogram would be the single decorative object on an otherwise undecorated site.

What the identity has instead is a rule: one blue line, one weight, marking the thing you are meant to read or the place you are currently in. It sits under the name, under the active navigation item, and nowhere else. Used with that much discipline, a line is enough to be recognised by.

RULES OF USE

- The rule is the width of the name, never longer
- Clear space = one cap height on all four sides
- Minimum width 84px; below that, the initials alone
- Never boxed, outlined, rotated, tinted, or set over a photograph

Weights, offsets and file formats follow at build stage; this page is here for you to approve the idea.

PRIMARY LOCKUP

Daniel Mercer

INTEGRATIVE COUNSELLING

Cover, correspondence, print. The rule is the width of the name and never longer.

SMALL USE • FAVICON

DM DM

The initials exist because a browser tab requires something. They are never used as a mark in their own right.

HORIZONTAL LOCKUP

Daniel Mercer

SHEFFIELD AND ONLINE

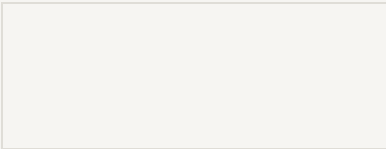
Website header and footer. The rule stands up and becomes the left edge of the block.

ON NEAR-BLACK • SINGLE COLOUR

Daniel Mercer

The name takes the paper colour; the rule keeps the blue, lifted to hold the same weight. Where one colour only is possible, both go paper.

Two neutrals, one signal.



Paper

#F6F5F2

THE PAGE

An off-white with no cream in it. Warm enough not to glare, cold enough not to read as a wellness palette.



Ink

#16181A

TYPE AND INVERSION

All primary type on paper, and the full-bleed ground for the two places where the practice states rather than explains: the process, and the refusals.



Graphite

#686C70

THE SECOND VOICE

Everything that supports rather than argues: captions, labels, notes, and the short answering line beneath each situation.

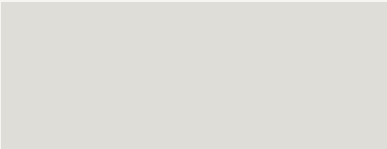


Signal

#1E3CF0

THE WAY IN

Links, the active navigation rule, the single button, and the rule under the name. Never a fill, never a heading, never decoration. On near-black it lifts to #5B7BFF.



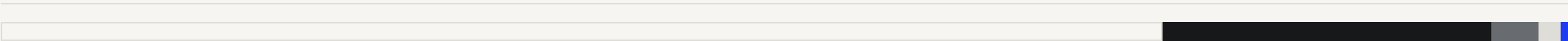
Hairline

#DFDDDD

SEPARATION

One weight only, for the rules that divide information. Never a border around a box, and never a fill.

PROPORTION ON ANY SCREEN



PAPER 74 INK 21 GRAPHITE 3 HAIRLINE 1.4 SIGNAL 0.6

Reassessed rather than assumed. We tested a version with no colour at all: without a signal the enquiry has to be found by reading, which is the one place this site cannot afford friction. One blue, used for nothing but the way in, does that job and adds no mood. A second accent was rejected, because two colours begin to describe a mood.

One voice for the argument. One for the facts.

INSTRUMENT SANS · THE ARGUMENT

Aa Daniel Mercer

A grotesque with no calligraphic gesture in it. It carries the headline, the situations, the body copy and the refusals. Letterforms with no hand in them match a voice with no performance in it.

HIERARCHY

DISPLAY	Instrument Sans Medium, 54	Two chairs and fifty minutes.
SECTION HEAD	Instrument Sans Medium, 26	Things I won't do
BODY	Instrument Sans Regular, 15.5	You talk. I listen properly.
SUPPORTING	Instrument Sans Regular, 14	It worked for a long time.
LABEL AND DATA	IBM Plex Mono Medium, 10	FEE · £60 · 50 MIN

IBM PLEX MONO · ANYTHING CHECKABLE

£60 50 min 01–04

A monospace for anything a reader can verify: the fee, the times, the numbered steps, section labels and form hints. Small sizes only, regular and medium, tabular figures throughout.

THE RULE

The monospace never carries a sentence, and the grotesque never sets a label. Anything checkable is set in the mono, so a sceptical reader can find every fact on a page without reading it first.

NOT USED

- A serif, anywhere
- Italic for emphasis; position does that job
- All-capital settings longer than three words
- Any third typeface, or a third size of heading

Photographs that answer questions.

WHAT THEY ARE FOR

Three questions the visitor will not ask out loud: who is he, what is the room actually like, and what will arriving there feel like. Each photograph answers one; none is there to make atmosphere.

THE ROOM

The consulting room as it is — mismatched chairs, a radiator, a sash window — not tidied into an interior. A styled room would look presented rather than ordinary.

THE PORTRAIT

Seated, in the room, in ordinary clothes, not looking at the lens. It should read as a photograph taken during work rather than one made for marketing.

LIGHT AND TREATMENT

Daylight from the window, visible shadow, no fill. A near-neutral grade: no warm filter, no drift towards cream. Square corners, full bleed or full column, no vignette.

SHOT LIST

01	02	03	04	05
The room, from the visitor's chair	The entrance hall and the stairs	The portrait, seated, mid-work	The two chairs, from the doorway	The street door, so the building is recognisable

A working list rather than a requirement. Three are essential — the room, the way in, and you. The site should still work if the last two are never taken.

NOT PHOTOGRAPHED

Hands holding mugs · tissue boxes and candles · plants, pebbles, water, woodland · anyone mid-gesture or mid-laugh · a staged session · stock images of calm · you standing with your arms folded

What follows for the website.

Each requirement follows from a conclusion on an earlier page. If a conclusion changes when you review it, the requirement changes with it. A designer should be able to build from this page without reopening the strategy.

THE ORDER OF THE PAGE

01 The claim

The headline is the largest thing on the page and the first thing rendered. The room photograph arrives with it, cutting across it, so claim and evidence land in one glance.

05 Things I won't do

The refusals, beside the process, in the same dark field, at reading size. The most distinctive thing on the site is given position rather than styling.

02 The situations

Eight lived situations in the visitor's own phrasing, one line each with a short answering line beneath. No condition list, no client types, nothing to click.

06 Practical information

Six rows — sessions, fee, where, availability, access, cancellations — as a full section rather than an FAQ, plus plain signposting for what the practice cannot serve.

03 The position

Managing isn't the same as being alright, and one paragraph on what the work actually consists of. No modality names without a definition beside them.

07 Who you are

Three paragraphs. The engineering years appear as recognition rather than credentials, and professional standing takes a single sentence.

04 How it works

Four numbered steps from email to weekly session, set in the near-black field. Prominence by inversion, not by decoration.

08 Contact

Name and email address. The message field is optional and says so, in the same sentence.

ENQUIRY FRICTION

One action, repeated: first screen, navigation, and a persistent bar on mobile. No newsletter, no download, no quiz, no booking funnel. The optional message field is not a usability nicety — a required box demanding that the visitor describe the difficulty is the performance the rest of the site has spent its time dismantling. The field must accept being left blank.

MOBILE

A primary layout, not a compression. The headline keeps its scale, the fee and the location sit in a fixed bar, and the practical rows stack in one column. The enquiry is usually made in a snatched moment, on a phone, in one sitting.

REPEATED, AND DELIBERATELY ABSENT

Repeated: the fee, and that the first step is only an email. Absent: badges, testimonials, outcome claims, statistics, a blog, a newsletter, and any sentence that requires the reader to already value therapy in order to understand it.

The practice on one page.

PROFESSIONAL IDENTITY

An integrative counsellor who explains his work in ordinary language, says what he notices, and treats the mechanics of therapy — the room, the fee, the process, the limits — as information the client is entitled to before arriving.

PHILOSOPHY

Nobody has to arrive able to explain the problem. What Daniel notices, said out loud, is part of the work; the change he describes is gradual rather than dramatic.

VOICE

Plain. Specific. Undramatic. Dry rather than funny. Reassurance delivered as information.

IDENTITY IDEA

A name and a rule — one blue line marking the way in, and no symbol at all.

VISUAL DIRECTION

Off-white and near-black, alternating for rhythm. One grotesque for the argument, one monospace for facts and labels. A single blue for links, the active rule and one button. Three photographs and no ornament.

PEOPLE TO REACH

Adults who are still functioning but whose long-standing way of coping has stopped working, and who assume they would be bad at therapy. Often men; often prompted by someone else; rarely in crisis.

CORE MESSAGE

You don't have to be good at talking to start.

DESIRED FEELING

Recognised. Unembarrassed. Informed. Met by something ordinary.

WEBSITE PRIORITY

Move the visitor from “this probably isn't for people like me” to a three-line email, without asking them to describe the problem first.

THE ONE TEST

Nothing on the site should require the visitor to be better at talking than they already are — the copy, the form, the navigation and the photographs alike.

Does this sound like your practice?

Once you approve it, this Blueprint is the agreed direction for the website. The build then works from these pages, so the time goes into making the site good instead of settling the same questions twice.

Read it once quickly and once slowly. Where something is factually wrong, correct it. Where the wording is right but not yours, say so — that is an equally useful correction. Where you disagree with a recommendation, say what you would want instead, or simply say it isn't you, and we will find the version that is.

Two consolidated rounds of revision are included at this stage. Sending your comments together produces a better document and a faster build.

WHAT TO REVIEW

- Factual accuracy, and the details still to confirm
- Whether the description on page 04 sounds like you
- The philosophy on page 05
- Who the site speaks to most directly
- The message and the voice
- The identity, and the decision not to have a symbol
- Colour, typography and photography
- The website requirements on page 14

AFTER APPROVAL

Design begins from the direction agreed here, so the website can concentrate on bringing it to life instead of reopening the same decisions.

Daniel Mercer

Prepared by Alexander Watson Studio · alexanderwatson.co.uk